

It was at that moment she felt her jeans give in the front. Her zipper had just broken. She was grateful for the long shirt she'd worn, sure that no one could tell. She breathed a huge sigh of relief, the first good breath she'd taken since zipping them up. By the time she reached the cereal aisle, Mary was getting a little irritated that the young man still seemed to be following her. This was where she had planned a good coupon attack. Many cereals were on sale for \$1.67 a box and she had dozens of 50¢ coupons. Her cart was already overflowing, and Mary was annoyed that other customers seemed to be staring. She was sure they were thinking that either she was a pig, or had an army to feed. At this point she would be relieved if the manager of the store announced that a mother of six was approaching the checkout.

Her face flushed, she juggled two boxes of cereal that fell off the cart and entered the checkout closest to the doors. Sweating with the effort of pushing the overloaded cart, she felt her underarms perspiring heavily, probably staining her blouse. As she waited in line, Mary straightened her blouse over the open zipper of her jeans, brushed back her unruly hair, and noticed the young man in the cookie aisle, still watching her. As the total approached the hundred dollar mark, she wished the floor would open up and swallow her. She knew she only had eighty dollars left in checking. She handed the cashier the stack of coupons and watched the total dwindle until she could triumphantly write out a check of \$72.89.

While the stock boy loaded up the back of her station wagon, Mary noticed the young man heading her way. Her mind racing, she wondered how to let him down. She was happily married, the mother of six. If her ravishing beauty had given him pause, had made him fall in love with her at first sight, it wasn't her fault. She always wore her wedding ring, she'd bought baby food, she drove a station wagon, for